

THE POWER OF SOCIAL NETWORKING

“Social networks are serious institutions and not for fun”

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Today I want to talk a bit about the Facebook story and what happened in the Obama campaign, but try to situate that into a much larger understanding of what is happening in the mind. I would like to start with a pretty simple concept—information. I define information as the recorded form of communication. Any time you have an idea, experience or emotion, as soon as any of it is captured and recorded, that becomes a piece of information. I, like many others, believe that we are experiencing an information revolution, the kind that comes along every few years.

This information revolution is of a unique historical type. Everyone who has any type of access to communications technology, be it Facebook, e-mail or SMS, has the ability to create information and distribute it widely, and consume it as well. The question then becomes, do we need support? What does this revolution mean for our society? And more importantly, how can people and organisations adapt to the new paradigm that we are in?

What better place to start than a Facebook profile? Facebook is a network that helps real people share and connect to the things that they care about. Here you recreate your authentic identity, connect to your real friends, and from there, because you are in a closed, trusted environment, you have total control of not only what information you share, but exactly who sees it.

One of the most asked questions to me is—what were you guys thinking? Where did this concept come from? Facebook came from a pretty basic generative environment which was the American University. The three of us—I, CEO of Facebook Mark Zuckerberg, and Dustin Moskovitz, another co-founder—were roommates in college studying different things. When we started Facebook in 2004, the basic idea was still present as it is today. Make it possible for people to talk about who they are, connect to their friends and do it in a trusted environment, and people will want to share. Over the past six years, Facebook has grown to the point where it has 400 million users and 70 per cent of those are outside the US.

There are plenty of opportunities in India that are already happening, even though many Indians are new to Facebook. It also gives unprecedented access to public figures and celebrities. Aamir Khan engages his supporters on

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